

FILM STUDIES

An Introduction

Ed Sikov

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CHAPTER 7

FROM SCREENPLAY TO FILM

DEEPER INTO NARRATIVE STRUCTURE

The screenwriter plays one of the key roles in the creation of a motion picture. He or she constructs a detailed story, maps out a scene-by-scene blueprint of the film's plot, and writes dialogue that may or may not sound like everyday life but that nonetheless fits the tone and style of the particular film. That's an important distinction. You may have the idea that movie dialogue must be realistic, but this is not the case. The script for Baz Luhrman's *Romeo + Juliet* (1996) features dialogue written by Shakespeare (and adapted by Luhrman and the screenwriter Craig Pearce), much of which is rhymed poetry. It's hardly "realistic," and yet it's perfectly appropriate for the film. Similarly, the tough-talking dialogue of a film noir ("We're both rotten, baby, only you're a little *more* rotten"—*Double Indemnity*, 1944) or the laconic speech of a western ("I wish I knew how to quit you"—*Brokeback Mountain*, 2005) may function beautifully in a particular work of film art despite the fact that you and your friends don't talk that way in everyday life.

It should be clear by this point that film studies does not ask you to be a movie reviewer. Your job is to examine rather than judge the films you see. You may like the characters or not or find the story uplifting or upsetting, but these personal responses—as important to you as they may be—are not crucial as far as the field of film studies is concerned. How, then, do you confront a film's story, if not to give it a thumbs-up or thumbs-down review?

The answer is: *analysis*. To analyze something means to break it down into its component parts. This holds true in chemistry as well as in film studies. In [chapter 6](#), you read a fairly simple analytical breakdown of the locations, characters, desires, and conflicts in *The Wizard of Oz*. You may or may not like *The Wizard of Oz*, and you can certainly argue its merits with your family and friends, but film studies asks you to analyze and understand the film rather than enjoy it. Hopefully your deeper understanding of the films you study will lead to greater enjoyment of them, but such pleasure is secondary. All of this is to say that analyzing narrative structure is not especially fun. In order to analyze a film's story and plot, you must stand far enough apart from it that you can see it clearly. Given the fact that most narrative films try to draw you in rather than keep you at an analytical distance, it's not easy to enjoy them and analyze them at the same time.

SCREENWRITING: THE THREE-ACT STRUCTURE

Despite what you may have heard about narrative screenwriting, particularly Hollywood screenwriting, there are no *rules* governing a feature-length screenplay's structure—only *conventions*. A CONVENTION is *an artistic practice or process or device that is commonly accepted and understood within a given culture*. Examples of film conventions range from the outlaw in a western and the hostile alien in a science fiction film to the 180° axis system described in [chapter 4](#) and the use of close-ups to express emotional intensity described in [chapter 1](#). Audiences understand and accept these conventions not despite their familiarity but because of it; if we were confronted by an absolutely original, truly unique device in any art form, we would likely not know what to make of it. We often like to think that great art is always totally original, but in point of fact it's usually a matter of varying established conventions, sometimes radically, rather than dispensing with them altogether. In the case of screenplays, some screenwriting professors may insist that their precepts—in other words, what they teach—must be strictly followed, particularly in terms of structure, but this is only true if the

screenwriter's goal is selling the screenplay to a large filmmaking corporation that expects to make not wildly original movies but movies that adhere to familiar conventions and thereby appeal to the largest possible audience.

One of the key conventions of narrative screenplays is known as the **three-act structure**. The origins of the idea that good dramas, which now include films, should have a beginning, middle, and end, can be traced to the ancient Greek philosopher Aristotle, who wrote his treatise *Poetics* around 335 BCE. In modern terms, Act One sets up the main character or characters and the situation in which he, she, or they find themselves. In Act Two, the middle, the main character or characters attempt to work out a problem caused at the end of Act One. The drama concludes in Act Three, in which the character or characters resolve his or her or their problems, usually by working through and resolving a crisis, which generally occurs at the end of the second act.

The three-act structure is a helpful tool for narrative screenwriters, who begin with a blank page and must fill about 120 such pages before they finish their first drafts. Having a three-part model to hold up as an ideal helps writers to build a series of incidents that will hold an audience's interest for two hours. It offers a basic blueprint for pacing the events of the story.

But because film studies is less about creating film art than analyzing it, we generally do not spend time trying to determine where the end of the first act is in a given film, or what constitutes the beginning of Act Three. Perhaps a better way of putting it is that such determinations are only the beginning. After all, many films do not follow precisely the three-act structure. Instead of trying to make the films we study conform to a preexisting model, we look closely, even minutely, at an individual film's plot to see the subtle narrative patterns that emerge. Every film's narrative has its own unique structure, and the process of discovering it is known as segmentation.

SEGMENTATION: FORM

In film studies, a formal analysis of a film's story and plot is called a SEGMENTATION. Segmentation provides a way to see and understand narrative patterns without being distracted by the tremendous sensory input of the rest of the film—without the loud sounds, exciting physical actions, and bright colors that contribute so much to the pleasure of moviegoing. Segmentations are straightforward, even dry outlines of what takes place in the film's narrative in the order in which the filmmakers present the events.

You will recall that a film's STORY is *all the events of the narrative as they occur in chronological order from beginning to end, including not only those that we see and hear, but those we infer*. The PLOT, on the other hand, is *the ordering and structuring of narrative events as they are presented in the film*. Segmentations are about plot—the order in which narrative elements occur. If, for example, a killer confesses to his crime in the beginning of the film, after which a series of flashbacks present the events leading up to the murder, a segmentation of the film would begin, just as the plot begins, with the confession. The story, on the other hand, takes a chronological form: it begins with a man embarking on the path that will result in his murdering the victim and ultimately confessing to the crime. The story ends with the confession; the plot—and the segmentation—begin with it.

Film narratives can be long and complicated, so a segmentation of a whole film begins by breaking the narrative down into its largest component parts. Once again, these parts tend to follow the model proposed by Aristotle in the fourth century BCE. These *dramatic unities*, also known as the *classical unities*, are (1) the unity of action, meaning that the main character or characters pursue only one goal; (2) the unity of place, which is to say that the action occurs in a single general location; and (3) the unity of time, meaning that the action takes place during a single time period. But while Aristotle's theory of the dramatic unities sets forth the idea that plays (and, by extension into modern terms, films) should observe all three unities from beginning to end, most films (and many plays) observe only the first unity—that of action. Given cinema's ability to bring multiple locations and time frames together during the course of their

90-minute or two-hour running time, most films ignore the second and third unities when it comes to the entire film. *Within scenes*, however, these unities are still observed, and it is on this basis that the largest, most basic individual units of segmentation are concerned.

A segmentation of a well-known movie may make this point clearer. *The Wizard of Oz*, as we have seen, can be segmented into three broad units based on the unity of space:

1. Kansas
2. Oz
3. Kansas

If the screenwriters and director of *The Wizard of Oz* had been forced to observe Aristotle's three unities for the duration of the film, they would not have been able to move Dorothy from Kansas to Oz and back. The filmmakers do adhere to the unity of action—Dorothy desires a better, more exciting life “over the rainbow” but learns, through her experiences in Oz, that “there's no place like home.” And they observe the unity of time as well, since the action of the film begins on the day of the tornado and ends with Dorothy waking up from what we assume to be a fairly brief period of unconsciousness afterward.

Within each of these three main segments, however, there are smaller units. The initial segment, taking place in Kansas, breaks down this way:

1. Kansas

(a) Auntie Em's farm, where Dorothy speaks of her fears for Toto's safety because of the evil Miss Gulch; to protect Toto, Dorothy decides to run away from home.

(b) On the road, Dorothy encounters the flamboyant Professor Marvel, who convinces her to go back to Auntie Em's.

(c) Auntie Em's farm, which is now deserted because of the impending tornado; the tornado strikes, Dorothy gets hit in the head, the house lifts off its foundation, and Dorothy and Toto are spirited into the air.

At this point, *each of the three segments (a, b, and c) observes all three classical unities*—action, place, and time. And there is a symmetry to the segments, one that matches the overall symmetrical pattern of the entire film; just as *The Wizard of Oz* moves from Kansas to Oz and back, the first segment moves from Auntie Em's farm to the road and back. When the house lands in the next segment, it lands in an entirely new location—"the merry old land of Oz," specifically Munchkin Land. And while time appears to be more or less continuous between the old location (the house sitting on its foundation in Kansas) and the new location (the house sitting on a dead witch in Munchkin Land), the unity of action shifts from Dorothy's desire to keep Toto away from Miss Gulch to Dorothy's desire to keep the ruby slippers away from Miss Gulch's double, the Wicked Witch of the West, the enraged sister of the (very) recently deceased witch.

SEGMENTATION: MEANING

Our partial segmentation of *The Wizard of Oz* is devoted to narrative form and its symmetrical, mirror-like structure. But as we explored its structure in [chapter 6](#), we began to see how structure leads to meaning. It is precisely by way of tools such as segmentation (and mise-en-scene, montage, and so on) that film scholars base whatever claims we make about a given film's politics and ideology. In film studies, it's not so much a question of *what happens* in a movie as *the way it happens*, and this is certainly true as far as plot patterns are concerned. Filmmakers use narrative structure not only to tell stories but to raise issues and make arguments, sometimes explicitly, sometimes implicitly.



FIGURE 7.1 Dalton (Clive Owen) in the preface of Spike Lee's *Inside Man* (2006) (frame enlargement).

Spike Lee's *Inside Man* (2006) is a good case in point. Based on a screenplay by Russell Gewirtz, *Inside Man* is—on the surface—a bank heist drama starring Denzel Washington, Clive Owens, and Jodie Foster. A segmentation of the film, however, reveals not only its formal structural patterns but also an implicit political argument about race and perception, or misperception as the case may be.

A SEGMENTATION OF *INSIDE MAN*

PART A. External Appearances: The Pseudo-Crime. Preface: Unknown space: Dalton (Clive Owen), a white man, introduces himself and says he attempted a perfect bank robbery.

1. Alternation: outside and inside the bank: The robbery begins; detective Frazier (Denzel Washington), an African American is assigned; Arthur Case (Christopher Plummer), the head of the bank, a white man, learns of the robbery; the robbers force the hostages to put on dark overalls and white masks that render them all but indistinguishable from one another; Captain Darius (Willem Dafoe) is introduced.

Interrogation: An African American man describes having been a hostage.

2. Inside the bank: Dalton in the bank's basement; Outside the bank: the penthouse of Madeleine White (Jodie Foster), who takes a phone call from Case.

Interrogation: Several hostages tell their stories.

3. Outside the bank: Frazier and Darius discuss the crisis; Case tells White about a secret safety deposit box; Alternation: outside and inside: Frazier attempts to call Dalton but Dalton doesn't pick up.

Interrogation: A female hostage.

4. Outside the bank: A Sikh hostage is released, and the cops remove his religiously mandated turban; the mayor's office: White convinces the mayor to let her intervene.

Interrogation: the Sikh complains about his racial treatment.

5. Outside the bank: Frazier, Mitchell, and Darius discuss Dalton's demands; Case attempts to join them but is rebuffed; the cops decide to send in pizza boxes outfitted with audio transmitters; Inside the bank: a hostage is beaten for taking off his mask.

Interrogation: a Jewish hostage.

6. Alternation between outside and inside the bank: the pizza is delivered; cops listen via the transmitters as the robbers seem to speak Russian; the female robber is disguised as a hostage.

Interrogations: two hostages are shown snapshots of other hostages.

7. Alternation between inside and outside: a hole has been chopped into the storage room floor; the language is identified as Albanian; Dalton and a young African American boy play a violent video game; Dalton opens (safety deposit) Box 392; White, the mayor, and Frazier discuss the situation.

Interrogation: an Armenian American hostage is asked if he is Albanian.

8. Alternation between inside and outside the bank: the robbers have bugged the command center; White enters the bank; Case's background as a Nazi collaborator is revealed; White insults Frazier.

Interrogations: the African American boy is asked if he recognizes anyone in the snapshots and says that "with the mask they all look the same"; a Latino hostage refers to a detective as "Wassa Wassa," which he defines as slang for "a person that don't come to your neighborhood"; a Jewish hostage; a female hostage.

9. Alternation between inside and outside the bank: Frazier is shown the hostages and tussles with Dalton; the robbers appear to shoot a hostage to death; Frazier discusses race and violence with a white cop; the cops storm the bank; the hostages are released, treated roughly by the cops, and taken away. Fade out. **End of PART A.**

10. **PART B. Internal Realities: The Real Crime.** Fade in: Frazier is told to "bury" a piece of information; Case confesses his past to White.

Unknown space: Dalton faces the camera and states his name—a repeat of the preface; this continues as voice-over into a flashback of Dalton in the bank's storage room fingering diamonds as the other robbers build a fake wall; Dalton is seen hiding behind it, then emerging.

11. Alternation between inside and outside the bank: three of the four robbers sit in a car outside the bank along with one of the supposed hostages; Dalton prepares to leave the bank; on his way out, Dalton bumps into Frazier, who is on his way in; Frazier opens Box 392.

12. Outside the bank: Frazier confronts Case; Frazier confronts White and the mayor; Frazier finds a diamond in his pocket.

13. Flashback: Inside: Dalton bumps into Frazier, shot from a different angle.

Coda: Frazier's girlfriend invites him into bed. **END.**

This segmentation of *Inside Man* divides the narrative into thirteen parts, with a preface and a coda framing them. These thirteen segments, in turn, are interrupted by seven interrogation scenes that take place in chronological terms after the hostages have been released but before Frazier has concluded his investigation. Notice in this context the difference between *Inside Man*'s plot and its story. In the story, which runs chronologically from beginning to end, the robbery is committed first; the story ends with Dalton confessing his crime. The plot, however, begins with Dalton's confession—the preface—and concludes with Frazier returning home to his girlfriend in the coda. In the story, the interrogations occur between segments 9 and 10 of the narrative; in the plot, they are interspersed at intervals between segments 1 and 9.

Inside Man appears to treat racial issues only incidentally. Compared to some of Spike Lee's other films, like *Do the Right Thing* (1989) and *Malcolm X* (1992), *Inside Man* may seem to be only mildly interested in perceptions of race and ethnicity. But in his book *American Film/American Culture*, the film scholar John Belton makes the case that the film's temporal shifts between the sequential events of the robbery and its aftermath on the one hand and the hostage interrogations on the other hand serve to reveal Lee's linking of race relations with perception and misperception, as two of the supposed hostages—who are in fact robbers or accomplices—

slip past the detectives, while several of the real hostages are treated unfairly because of their race or ethnicity. Belton writes:

Lee's playful manipulation of time and space foregrounds the problem of perception and misperception. Though the nominal subject of the film is the face-off between cops and criminals during a bank robbery, Dalton Russell and his gang harbor a hidden agenda that involves securing evidence that will expose Case's crimes against Jewish victims of the Holocaust. In other words, the film is also about race. New York City's multiculturalism is highlighted through a proliferation of characters representing different races and ethnicities, including African Americans, Albanians, Armenians, Asians, Hispanics, Jews, Poles, Saudi Arabians, and Sikhs. The title music—"Chaiyya, Chaiyya"—is an Islamic Indian love song from a popular Hindi film, further announcing the film's concern with other cultures.

Lee's inclusion of seemingly random instances of racism provides a subtext on race that links racism to biased perception or misperception. The (white) cop on the beat who discovers the robbery tells Frazier, who is black, a story about his first violent encounter with a 12-year-old who stuck a gun in his face. He talks about breaking up a fight in which "one little spic is getting his clocked cleaned by another" when "a ni ..., an African American" pulled a gun on him. With the n-word on his lips, he suddenly realizes who he's talking to and says "African American" instead. Even Capt. Darius (Willem Dafoe) indulges in racist epithets, referring to "those ragheads at the Munich Olympics." A Sikh hostage is released; because he wears a turban, the police perceive him as an Arab terrorist and throw him to the ground.

Frazier's misreading of the bank robbery, though in no way racist, becomes the thematic center with which these other instances of biased perception resonate. Lee's choreography of the ending of the film involves the pooling of efforts on the part of the film's three major characters—a black man (Frazier), a white man (Russell), and a white woman (White)—to expose Case's criminal past. Three of the film's most visible non-racists take down the film's invisible racist. The moral imperative of the film is articulated by Russell in his final voice-over. Acknowledging that he robbed the bank for the money, he also admits to another motive, noting that the money's "not worth much if you can't face yourself in the mirror. Respect is the ultimate currency." Respect—both self-respect and respect for others—becomes the foundation on which a new, non-racist moral order can be built. (John Belton, *American Cinema/American Culture*, 3d ed., New York: McGraw-Hill, 2008)

STUDY GUIDE: STORY ANALYSIS AND SEGMENTATION

Segmentations can be time-consuming. You must stop and start the film many times in order to take notes, and if the film is at all entertaining to you, you will likely resent having to disengage yourself from what is happening in order to concentrate on the task at hand. The segmentation of *Inside Man* above took many hours to complete and was originally eight single-spaced pages long. Only after several more hours of whittling it down to its basic segments did the film's core narrative pattern emerge.

Unless your professor assigns you to write a segmentation of an entire film, here are two ideas for cutting down the sheer amount of work involved in doing a segmentation: (1) Segment a film with which you are already very familiar, and (2) Only segment part of a film.

Segmenting a film you know well will enable you to avoid getting so caught up in the action that you forget to analyze the narrative. Whether it is *Alien* (1979) or *The Sound of Music* (1965), your prior knowledge of the film's story will enable you to concentrate on its plot.

Segmenting only part of a film is also possible, although it may provide misleading results. You will save some time if you analyze, say, the first twenty minutes of a film instead of the whole thing, but while you will gain the experience of tracing a specific narrative's development, your analysis will be partial and possibly distorted. For example, were you to analyze only the first part of *Inside Man*, you would not see the larger pattern formed by the interrogations, only the first of which would appear in your segmentation. To avoid misrepresenting the narrative's structure, be sure to watch the rest of the film carefully, remaining aware of any broad patterns that emerge and noting them accordingly.

WRITING ABOUT WRITING

The search for meaning, and the articulation of ideas about meaning, continues as the central theme of this last section. Let's take a second look at John Belton's analysis of *Inside Man* to see specifically how Belton used segmentation and close observation to put together an argument about what the film means:

1. Lee's playful manipulation of time and space foregrounds the problem of perception and misperception. Though the nominal subject of the film is the face-off between cops and criminals during a bank robbery, Dalton Russell and his

gang harbor a hidden agenda that involves securing evidence that will expose Case's crimes against Jewish victims of the holocaust. In other words, the film is also about race.

In this paragraph, Belton makes a logical connection between the film's nonchronological time structure and the theme of misperception, concluding that the combination of these elements— *unclear temporal structure* plus *theme of misperception* equals the film's otherwise hidden subject matter: *race*. It's an ingenious assertion. Here's how Belton supports it with evidence:

2. New York City's multiculturalism is highlighted through a proliferation of characters representing different races and ethnicities, including African Americans, Albanians, Armenians, Asians, Hispanics, Jews, Poles, Saudi Arabians, and Sikhs. The title music—"Chaiyya, Chaiyya"—is an Islamic Indian love song from a popular Hindi film, further announcing the film's concern with other cultures.

So far so good; Belton provides details of all the racial, ethnic, religious, and national communities represented by characters in *Inside Man*. By listing these groups, Belton is laying on details that support his argument that the film contains a social and political theme underlying its surface bank-robbery subject.

3. Lee's inclusion of seemingly random instances of racism provides a subtext on race that links racism to biased perception or misperception. The (white) cop on the beat who discovers the robbery tells Frazier, who is black, a story about his first violent encounter with a 12-year-old who stuck a gun in his face. He talks about breaking up a fight in which "one little spic is getting his clocked cleaned by another" when "a ni ..., an African American" pulled a gun on him. With the n-word on his lips, he suddenly realizes who he's talking to and says "African American" instead. Even Capt. Darius (Willem Dafoe) indulges in racist epithets, referring to "those ragheads at the Munich Olympics." A Sikh hostage is released; because he wears a turban, the police perceive him as an Arab terrorist and throw him to the ground.

In this paragraph, Belton links incidents of racism to thematic questions about the nature of perception. He provides clear, accurate descriptions of three incidents in the film that relate to these issues, blends visual, aural and story descriptions, and methodically lays out his case.

4. Frazier's misreading of the bank robbery, though in no way racist, becomes the thematic center with which these other instances of biased perception resonate. Lee's choreography of the ending of the film involves the pooling of efforts on the part of the film's three major characters—a black man (Frazier), a white man (Russell), and a white woman (White)—to expose Case's criminal past. Three of the film's most visible non-racists take down the film's invisible racist. The moral imperative of the film is articulated by Russell in his final voice-over. Acknowledging that he robbed the bank for the money, he also admits to another motive, noting that the money's "not worth much if you can't face yourself in the

mirror. Respect is the ultimate currency.” Respect—both self-respect and respect for others—becomes the foundation on which a new, non-racist moral order can be built.

In this final paragraph, Belton ties up his assertion about misperceptions with clear, concise evidence from the film and offers a conclusion that spins out from the individual movie to the greater realm of politics and culture. Had Belton begun with his final sentence (“ Respect—both self-respect and respect for others—becomes the foundation on which a new, non-racist moral order can be built”) without logically leading the reader through his evidence-based argument step by step, his point would not stand; there would be no foundation for it to rest on. But by using logic, ingenuity, creative thinking, and accurate quotations from the film, Belton makes a solid case and a convincing argument. Keep this strategy in mind for any writing assignments you are asked to do, not only in this course but in your other courses as well.